his Chinese counterpart Li Peng, paid an official visit to China between 19 and 23 December 1988. It was the first such visit by an Indian prime minister, since his grandfather Jawaharlal Nehru travelled to Beijing in October 1954. Rajiv Gandhi held meetings with China's top leaders, climbed the Great Wall, and, at official banquets, the exquisitely carved vegetable decorations were in the shape of a dragon, symbolizing China, a peacock, symbolizing India, and two doves, symbolizing peace.[30] Perhaps because of the recent incidents along the border, the Indian prime minister was received with utmost respect. China had certainly changed a lot since 1962, but so had India.

Rajiv Gandhi's landmark visit marked the beginning of a thaw in Sino-Indian relations. In December 1991, Chinese Premier Li Peng reciprocated Rajiv Gandhi's visit by going to New Delhi. High-level visits became routine in the 1990s and, when, in September 1993, Pamulaparti Venkata Narasimha Rao, then prime minister, visited China, agreements were signed on maintaining peace and tranquillity along the crest of the Himalayas. In November 1996, China's President Jiang Zemin visited India, and the two countries agreed to a set of confidence-building measures to be implemented along the common border.[31]

After decades of confrontation, Sino-Indian relations were improving. While significant progress was made, it also became clear, once again, that China and India were fundamentally different civilizations with incompatible political systems. During Rajiv Gandhi's visit, many had hoped for a breakthrough on the border question. But that was not to come. In 1960, China had proposed a straight east-west territorial exchange, including India, abandoning Aksai Chin in the west in return for China accepting the Himalayan crest line or the McMahon Line in the east. In other words, the Line of Actual Control would become a new, demarcated border.[32]

It would not have been difficult for the Chinese to agree to such a deal, as no one in China would dare oppose the government's policies on matters of vital strategic concern. India, on the other hand, is a democracy where leaders and politicians have to face the public in general elections. It would be political suicide for any Indian politician to suggest that India should give up Aksai Chin, an area which it considers part of its territory, in return for recognition of sovereignty over land it already controls, that is, the